The issues

On an unseasonably warm March evening in Tel Aviv, an hour after Shabbat, the cafés and restaurants along fashionable Rothschild Boulevard were overflowing. Further down the road, in stark contrast, a few dozen Israelis were camped in the median, trying to recreate the tent city that became the nucleus of the 2011 socioeconomic protests.

The largest crowds were streaming into Rabin Square for an anti-Netanyahu rally. It would be the city's largest political demonstration in four years. The keynote speaker was Meir Dagan, a former Mossad chief who seemed out of place amidst a sea of Meretz flags. Ariel Sharon, after all, once said that "Dagan's speciality is separating an Arab from his head."

But Dagan had become a savage critic of the prime minister since he had left the agency in 2011. Days earlier, he denounced part of Netanyahu's speech to Congress about the nuclear deal with Iran as "bullshit". On this Saturday evening, he warned the crowd that Israel would become an apartheid state if it did not reach an agreement with the Palestinians. He looked frail, and choked back tears as he spoke. (He had been battling liver cancer, and would die the following March, exactly one year after the election.)

"Israel is surrounded by enemies. Our enemies do not scare me; I'm worried about our leadership," he said. "The crisis we are experiencing today is the worst I can remember since the founding of the state." He was the most prominent face in an unprecedented generals' revolt, with hundreds of retired commanders joining a vocal coalition against Netanyahu.

Hermann has long conducted a monthly survey called the "Peace Index." The first campaign-season survey, conducted in late December, found 56 per cent of Israeli Jews "strongly" or "moderately" in favor of negotiations with the Palestinians. Ten years earlier, it was 75 per cent. Meanwhile, only 30 per cent of the Jewish public believed that negotiations between Israel and the Palestinians would lead to peace in the coming years—down from 46 per cent a decade ago.

Put those numbers together, in other words, and less than one-third of Jewish Israelis support negotiations and actually believe a two-state solution is possible. A solid majority think—for better or worse—that the status quo cannot be changed.